

Autonomous Driving Project — Documentation

TUM “Introduction to ROS” 2026 — Autonomous Driving group project

This document explains the architecture, design decisions, external dependencies, known limitations, and results of our submission. See the repository `README.md` for install/build/run instructions, and `DEEP_DIVE.md` in the same `docs/` directory for the full engineering-detail version of everything below (every algorithm, every parameter’s exact value and the reasoning behind it, a complete bug history, and the performance/testing methodology).

1 System Overview

The car drives a fixed ~785m urban loop published once at startup from a pre-recorded, lane-snapped set of waypoints. Five ROS 2 packages we wrote ourselves sit on top of two packages provided by the course (`simulation`, the Unity TCP/UDP bridge, and `dummy_controller`, an unused reference example) and several external ROS libraries:

A single launch file (`bringup/main.launch.py`) starts every node, the static TF tree, and RViz. See Section 3 for the full, auto-generated ROS graph.

2 Packages and Nodes

2.1 Perception

`obstacle_guard_node` receives the depth camera’s point cloud (converted to `sensor_msgs/PointCloud2` by the external `depth_image_proc` component), transforms every point into the world frame via `tf2`, and classifies each against the closest segment of the currently-planned trajectory. Points with world height in `[0.35, 3.0]` m are kept (below that is road-surface noise and low sidewalk fringes); four corridor distances are published, including a `tight` corridor used both for ACC following and for verifying a detour path is actually clear before committing to it.

`traffic_light_node` classifies connected components in an HSV-thresholded mask of the facing camera image, filtering blobs by shape (compact, roughly square, well-filled) to reject false positives such as the red ring of no-U-turn signs or red shop banners. Only red and green are detected — the amber phase is skipped because the signal casing is itself amber-painted metal and cannot be reliably separated from a lit amber lamp; the controller treats “stopped, no fresh green yet” as “keep waiting,” which is compliant behaviour.

2.2 Planning

2.2.1 Base Path Generation

`route_planner_node` loads the recorded waypoints and, once at startup, builds a fixed *base path*: a right-hand lane offset (so the car drives its own side of the road instead of straddling the recorded centre-line, tuned per-stretch to available road width and eased out in sharp turns to avoid curbs or junction edges), iterative smoothing (removes jaggedness that would otherwise read as artificially tight curvature), and a curvature- and acceleration-limited speed profile (tighter curves get a lower limit; braking/accelerating

passes in each direction cap how fast speed can change between consecutive points). The resulting path — position, heading, curvature, and speed per point — is published once as the planner’s live trajectory.

2.2.2 Detour Replanning and Goal Selection

On top of the static base path, `route_planner_node` handles two on-line updates: obstacle detours requested by `control`, and continuous short-term goal selection over the task’s predefined pose list.

When `control` confirms a static obstacle, the planner shifts a short stretch of the base path sideways just enough to clear it, blending smoothly back into the original line on either side (no abrupt lateral jump), then reverts once the obstacle is reported clear. It locates the affected stretch by binary-searching the path’s arc-length ordering rather than rescanning the whole route, and re-runs the detoured section through the same speed profile as the base path.

Independently, the planner tracks vehicle progress and publishes the nearest still-ahead goal from the task’s predefined pose list. Because the route loops back near itself, a plain nearest-point search would be ambiguous between two nearby but unrelated points; the planner resolves this once at startup with a heading-filtered search that locks onto the correct pass, then stays locked on with a cheaper position-windowed local search.

2.3 Control

`pure_pursuit_node` tracks the published trajectory with a standard pure-pursuit lateral law (steering from a geometric look-ahead point, not a PID error term [2]) and a throttle law combining proportional correction with a feed-forward table — added because a plain proportional law alone settles measurably below its commanded speed at steady state against the simulator’s own drag; the table is calibrated directly against that measured gap. On top of that:

- `/control/enable service` (`std_srvs/SetBool`, the project’s required self-implemented ROS service): `false` holds the brake (the default at launch, `start_enabled:=false`), `true` releases it to drive — used to hold the car at a known state before a timed test run.
- **ACC-style gap control** slows for anything in the tight/main corridor ahead, with a distance-scaled approach cap.
- **Traffic-light state machine** stops at the correct

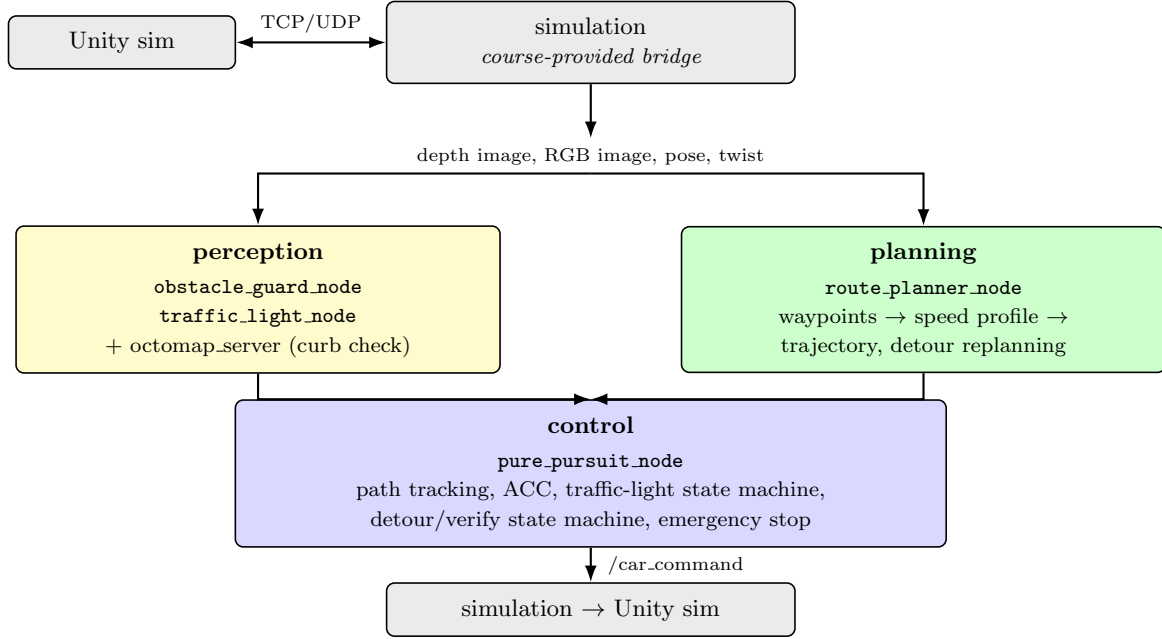


Figure 1: High-level node/data-flow architecture. Perception and planning consume the simulator’s sensor/pose streams independently and run in parallel; **control** is the only node that combines their outputs and the sole path to `/car_command` — no other node talks to the simulator directly.

stop line for a red phase and releases on a confirmed green; a bounded blind-release timer covers the one junction (TL4) whose signal head leaves the camera’s field of view right at the stop line — see Section 5 for the honest limitation here.

- **Obstacle detour state machine** (`kNormal` -> `kVerify` -> `kDetour`, with a `kHold` fallback) proactively replans around a static obstacle once confirmed parked (tracked as static vs. moving by watching its world position over a few seconds), verifies the shifted path is clear before committing, and threads it.
- **Emergency stop**: every control tick, independent of the above, computes the deceleration required to stop before the nearest raw corridor obstacle ($a = v^2/(2d)$) and immediately commands full brake if that exceeds a threshold — this is the task’s Event II (“NPC crosses then brakes hard”) handling.
- **Supplementary OctoMap cross-check**: `obstacle_guard_node` also publishes `/perception/map_tight_distance` from `octomap_server`’s accumulated occupancy map (height-banded to 0.08–0.35 m, the range the live per-frame filter ignores). `kVerify` ANDs this in: a fresh map hit can additionally veto a detour the live sensor alone approved (catching a curb the live sensor structurally can’t see), but a stale/absent reading never blocks anything by itself. Two bounded-trust safeguards prevent an indefinite hold: the map signal is ignored if stale, and a map-only block can hold for at most 25 s before falling back to the live sensor alone.

3 ROS Graph

Generated directly from the launch file (not hand-drawn): nodes are ellipses, topics are the labeled edges (direction = publisher -> subscriber), and color groups nodes by author, matching Section 2’s ownership column.

4 Results

A full run of the finished system (`bringup/main.launch.py`, default parameters, telemetry logged for these figures): **272 s, zero collisions, zero stalls, one detour, two red-light stops handled correctly** — the detour at the same static obstacle and TL2/TL3 each requiring a stop-and-release have repeated identically across every regression run this cycle. The route has four signal-controlled stop points total (TL1–TL4, see Section 5); TL2/TL3 have consistently been red on arrival, TL1/TL4 consistently green. Because phase-on-arrival depends on the real-time sim clock at spawn, a differently-timed run could see a different subset require a stop — the same stop/wait/release logic (Section 2.3) applies regardless of which junction is red, so that would be a different *subset firing*, not different documented behavior.

The route also includes the task’s Event II encounter (a second vehicle crossing then braking, met on the return leg): in every checked run it appears at the same location ($\sim s=531$), handled by the ACC gap-following logic alone (speed easing to ~ 0.5 m/s, no stop, no emergency brake) — one of the near-zero dips in Figure 4. The dedicated emergency-stop branch is a backstop for a faster-closing version of this encounter

Package	Owner (EDIT)	Node(s)	Responsibility
simulation	course-provided	unity_TCP_stream_receiver ROS_command_transmitter	TCP/UDP bridge to Unity: publishes ground-truth pose/twist, camera/IMU data; sends VehicleControl commands. Ported to ROS 2 Jazzy, not otherwise modified.
dummy_controller	course-provided	—	Minimal example controller from the course. Not used by bringup ; kept only for reference.
project_interfaces	Author 1	—	Our custom message types: Trajectory/TrajectoryPoint (planned path with per-point speed) and TrafficLight (detected signal state).
perception	Author 2	obstacle_guard_node	Transforms the depth-camera point cloud into the world frame and measures arc-length distance to the nearest obstacle along the planned trajectory in four corridors (main/tight/overtake-left/overtake-right), plus an OctoMap cross-check for curb-height obstacles the live scan misses (Section 2.3).
perception	Author 2	traffic_light_node	RGB HSV blob detection of the facing signal head. Deliberately does not use the semantic camera (bonus criterion).
planning	Author 3	route_planner_node	Builds a lane-snapped, curvature-limited-speed trajectory from the recorded waypoints; reactively replans a lateral detour around a confirmed static obstacle; selects the nearest still-ahead goal from the task's predefined pose list.
control	Author 1	pure_pursuit_node	Pure-pursuit path tracking, ACC (Adaptive Cruise Control)-style gap control, traffic-light stop/go state machine, detour engage/verify/thread/hold state machine, emergency braking. Implements the required <code>/control/enable</code> service.
bringup	Author 3	—	Single launch file, static TF tree (sensor extrinsics per the task sheet's vehicle drawing), RViz config.

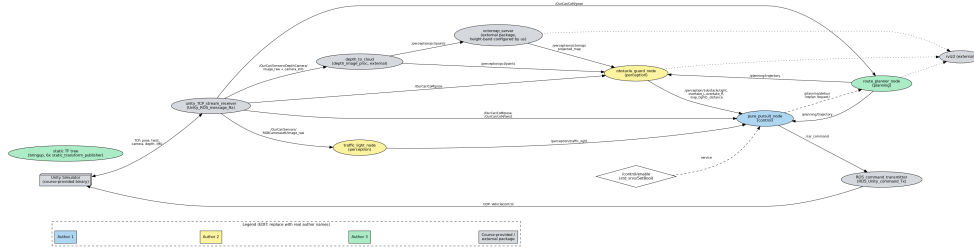


Figure 2: ROS computation graph, colored by author. Author colors are placeholders — see the table in Section 2 for the current mapping; replace with real names before submission.

and has not itself fired in testing.

- Average speed **2.7 m/s**, peak **7.5 m/s** on the two longest clear straights.
- Figure 3: driven path colored by speed — dark (near-zero) points mark the detour, Event II, and the two light stops; speed peaks on the long straights.
- Figure 4: the same data vs. distance — five near-zero dips (detour wait, two ACC-managed slowdowns including Event II, two light stops), re-accelerating smoothly after each.
- The distance-travelled axis reads **~721 m** vs. the route's documented **~785 m**: a straight-line, point-to-point Euclidean sum over 10 Hz samples undercounts on curves (chord vs. arc) — a measurement artifact, not a shorter drive.
- Figure 5 shows the finished route overlaid on the course map, with the ten predefined goal poses (0–9) marked — the actual input to Section 2.2.2's goal-selection logic.

5 Known Limitations / Requirements Not Fully Met

- **TL4 blind-release timing**: this junction's signal head is detectable only right at the stop line, so the car sometimes releases without a confirmed-fresh phase reading. The 22s release-timer bound comes from the red-phase duration measured at TL1 (the only junction whose head stays visible long enough to time a full cycle) and is assumed, not independently confirmed, to also bound TL4 — TL4's own red duration can't be measured the same way. Even at face value, the red phase (22s) exceeds the following green+amber window (14s), so for any fixed-delay timer with no live visibility there exists an arrival offset where release lands inside the *next* red phase (worst case ~8s unavoidable overlap) — a physical limitation of the intersection's timing, not something a control-side fix alone can eliminate.
- **OctoMap curb cross-check** (Section 2.3) is code-reviewed and bounded-safe (verified not to introduce false blocks/hangs across regression runs) but never actually triggered — this route's one obstacle isn't at curb height the live sensor misses. Included as

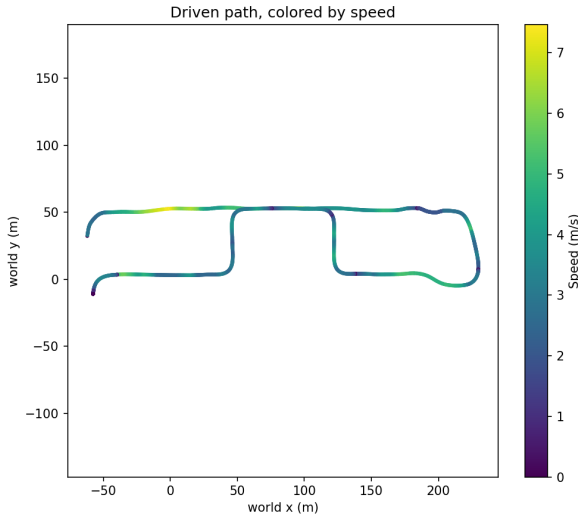


Figure 3: Driven path, colored by instantaneous speed.

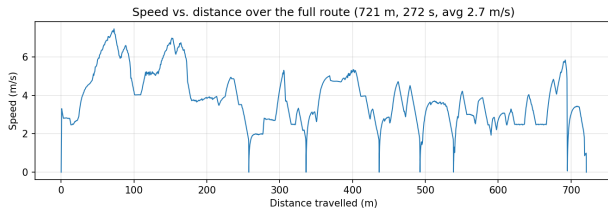


Figure 4: Speed vs. distance travelled over the full route.

a safety net for cases the live corridor structurally can't see, not because we observed it catch something.

- **Perception update rate** ($\sim 0.7\text{--}1\text{ Hz}$ for point-cloud-derived corridor distances) is bounded by Unity's own single-core render/physics loop — confirmed across several look-ahead/decimation settings in our own code, not fixable from the ROS side. This caps how much cruise speed can be raised before stale-corridor braking becomes frequent.

6 External Code / Not Written by Us

- **simulation, dummy_controller**: provided by the course (maintainers Markus Ryll, Jiaming Zhang), ported to ROS 2 Jazzy; not modified beyond what porting required.
- **depth_image_proc** (PointCloudXYZNode), **octomap_server**, **tf2_ros**, **rviz2**, **rclcpp/rclcpp-components**, **std_srvs**, **cv_bridge**, **OpenCV**: standard ROS 2 / third-party libraries, used as-is via their public APIs and launch-file parameters (not modified); see bibliography.
- Everything in **project_interfaces**, **perception**, **planning**, **control**, and **bringup**'s launch file / TF tree is written by us.

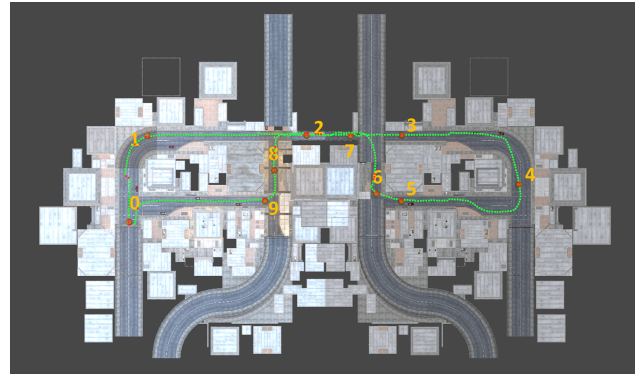


Figure 5: Planned route overlaid on the course map, with the ten predefined goal poses (0–9) used for short-term goal selection.

7 Team & Contributions

(Placeholder — replace with real names.)

Author	Contributions
1	control : path tracking, ACC, traffic-light/detour state machines, emergency stop, <code>/control/enable</code> ; project_interfaces
2	perception : corridor monitoring, OctoMap cross-check, HSV traffic-light detection
3	planning : trajectory gen., detour replanning, goal selection; bringup

References

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- [3] A. Hornung, K. M. Wurm, M. Bennewitz, C. Stachniss, and W. Burgard, “OctoMap: An Efficient Probabilistic 3D Mapping Framework Based on Octrees,” *Autonomous Robots*, 34(3), pp. 189–206, 2013.
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- [10] Unity Technologies, *Unity Engine* (course-provided simulation binary).
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